FriendZone Interview Results

1 From your experience, how do new residents usually start connecting with other people in the accommodation?

a Mainly based on shared interests, such as fitness and travel, or shared daily routines, like taking the same class or shared common area.

b Well, because I live in student accommodation, I think the accommodation I talk about here means student accommodation. When new residents first move in, they usually don't know much about the new place. So they may email or call the reception to ask questions. If they ask in person, they may go to the reception desk and talk to the staff or an RA.

c When I first came to Brisbane, I didn't know many people here. From what I have seen, new residents usually start by talking to their roommates or people living on the same floor. Sometimes the conversation begins in a very simple way, like meeting someone in the lift or kitchen and asking where they are from or what they study.
Some residents also meet through welcome events or accommodation group chats. For me, I'm a little slow to warm up, so I usually don't become friends with someone after just one conversation. I need to see the person a few times before I feel comfortable talking more.

2 What kinds of social interactions do you commonly observe between residents?

a Most of these interactions take place in shared common areas, where residents spend the vast majority of their time simply chatting, though they occasionally play games or hold parties.

b To be honest, um, I'm not really sure what kind of "social interactions" this question means. But if I need to give an example, the accommodation may hold some events, and residents who join these events may talk and interact with each other.

c Most of the interactions I see are quite casual. People say hello in the lift, talk while cooking, ask about university or complain about assignments. Sometimes residents also help each other collect parcels, borrow small things or share food.
People who already know each other may cook dinner, go shopping or go out together. I've also noticed that international students sometimes stay with people who speak the same language because it is easier and more comfortable. So there are many small interactions, but they do not always develop into close friendships.

3 Are there particular places or situations where residents are more likely to interact with each other?

a Common areas and parks near apartment buildings are the places where residents interact most closely with one another.

b Yes. For example, the terrace, the lobby, the gym, and the games room. Residents are more likely to meet and talk to each other in these shared spaces

c I think shared spaces are the easiest places, especially the kitchen, common room, lift and laundry area. The kitchen is probably the best one because people usually stay there for a while. You can ask what someone is cooking, and then the conversation starts naturally.
Events such as shared dinners, barbecues or game nights can also help. It is usually easier when people have something to do together. If everyone is only told to introduce themselves, it can feel a little forced or awkward, especially for quieter people.

4 What factors seem to make it easier for new residents to connect with others?

a If an apartment offers a wide range of recreational amenities such as an open rooftop and a gym, it can significantly increase interaction among residents.

b I think one factor is personality. For example, outgoing people may find it easier to make friends. Another factor is time. Usually, the longer people spend time together, the more familiar they become with each other

c Having something in common makes it much easier. For example, they may study at the same university, come from a similar cultural background or have the same hobbies. Even having similar problems, such as not knowing where to buy something, can start a conversation.
I also think the other person's attitude is important. Because English is not my first language, I feel more comfortable when someone is patient and does not speak too quickly. Seeing the same people regularly also helps. After saying hello several times, it becomes much easier to have a longer conversation.

5 What difficulties do residents commonly face when trying to make new social connections?

a It is more difficult to fit into a group than to make friends with individuals, so small groups in public spaces may discourage new residents from socializing.

b I think personality is one of the main difficulties. More introverted people may find it harder to make new social connections. Language can also be a problem. Many residents do not speak English as their first language, so sometimes communication can be a little difficult.

c For international students, language can be a big difficulty. Sometimes I understand what someone is saying, but I need more time to think about how to answer in English. By the time I have thought of an answer, the conversation may have already moved on. Because of this, I may look quieter than I really am. Another difficulty is that some residents already have their own friendship groups. It can be uncomfortable to join a group when everyone already knows each other. Postgraduate students can also be quite busy with classes, assignments or part-time work, so our free time may not match.

6 Do you notice any differences between residents who become socially connected quickly and those who remain more isolated?

a Yes, their willingness to socialize varies. Those who establish social connections quickly are usually more willing to accept invitations to events, so they get to know each other quickly.

b I think the main difference is personality. Outgoing people usually find it easier to join social groups and connect with other people quickly.

c The residents who connect quickly are usually more willing to start conversations. They attend more activities, spend time in common areas and are comfortable talking with people from different backgrounds. Their English may also be better, so they are less worried about making mistakes.
However, people who are more isolated are not necessarily unfriendly. Some are just shy, busy or less confident. Others may already have friends outside the accommodation. To be honest, when I first arrived, I was probably closer to this group. I needed more time before I felt comfortable with new people.

7 After residents first meet at an event or shared space, what seems to help them maintain that connection afterwards?

a More proactive invitations to activities or opportunities to help each other can help them stay in touch afterward.

b Having common interests can help them keep in contact.

I think exchanging contact details is the first step. People may add each other on Instagram, WhatsApp or WeChat. But just adding someone does not mean the connection will continue. Usually, one person needs to send another message or suggest doing something together.

c A specific invitation works better than saying, “Let’s meet sometime.” For example, asking someone to have dinner, go shopping or study together gives them a clear reason to meet again. Living close to each other also helps because people can continue seeing each other naturally.

8 If you could change or introduce something in the accommodation to help residents form and maintain social connections, what would it be?

a Enhance the recreational aspects of public spaces by adding more social activities, such as table games and video tapes to encourage resident participation.

b Um, I like playing video games, so for me, I would like the accommodation to add more game consoles, like a PS5 or NS2. But obviously, that might be too expensive for the accommodation’s budget, haha.

c I would introduce small, regular activities instead of only organising large events. For example, there could be a weekly dinner, coffee meeting, walking group or board-game night with around six to ten people. Personally, I would feel more comfortable in a small group because everyone has a chance to speak. At a large party, quieter residents can easily stay in one corner or only talk to people they already know. It would also be useful to have a group chat where residents could post simple invitations, such as asking whether anyone wants to cook, study or go shopping together.

9 Which of these activities seem to work well, and which seem to be less effective? Why?

a Recreational activities may encourage outgoing residents to take the initiative in inviting other residents for the first time. However, whether these activities actually increase participation among other residents largely depends on their own interests and attitudes toward making friends.

b Um, I assume this question means the activities held by the student accommodation. Personally, I think activities that are easy to join usually work better. For example, if residents can get free snacks, more people may join.

For activities that have some barriers, fewer residents may join. The barrier could be money, for example, if people need to pay a fee. It could also be about ability or physical activity, for example, yoga classes or hiking. I think these kinds of activities usually have fewer people joining.

I think activities involving food, games, walking or sport usually work well. People have something to focus on, so they do not need to keep thinking of new conversation topics. Regular activities are especially useful because residents can meet the same people several times and slowly become more familiar with each other.

c Large parties and one-time welcome events may be less effective for quieter residents. They can be noisy, and people often attend with friends they already know. Free food may attract many people, but it does not necessarily help them form lasting connections. I think smaller and repeated activities are more effective for building real friendships.